
Narrated Networks: Social Network Analysis of the Memoirs of Countess Luise Charlotte von Schwerin (1684-1732)

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Abstract

The memoirs of Countess Luise Charlotte von Schwerin (written around 1720), preserved in a TEI-encoded critical edition, offer a rare insight into the social, political, religious, and familial ties of an early modern noblewoman navigating Prussian and Austrian court environments. The digital edition is a cooperation between the Institute for the Study of the Habsburg Monarchy at the ÖAW and the Department of Digital Humanities at the University of Graz.

The memoir survives in two French manuscripts: Manuscript A (Aix-en-Provence, Bibliothèque Méjanes), published in 2013 (Daumas/Ulbrich), and Manuscript W, held at the Haus-, Hof- und Staatsarchiv in Vienna and discovered in 2016. Unlike diaries with regular dated entries, the memoirs present a retrospective, narratively structured account containing abundant references to persons, places, works, dates, and relational constellations (Galka et al. 2024). Building on recent work combining named entity recognition and social network analysis (Fields et al. 2023), on approaches highlighting women’s networks in early modern Europe (Medici 2018), and on the broader “network turn” in the humanities (Ahnert et al. 2021), this paper proposes a network analysis grounded explicitly in narration rather than daily record.

Using a TEI-derived dataset enriched with manually curated person metadata (GND, VIAF, Wikidata; created by Ines Peper and Michael Pölzl), person-based co-occurrence networks are created from the memoir’s encoded entities. Edge definitions have been refined beyond paragraph-level units to avoid excessive network density. Temporal networks were constructed from sentence-based narrated life phases defined by biographically meaningful divisions in the memoir (e.g. childhood and youth, marital and courtly life, successive Viennese stays), rather than uniform calendar intervals.

Special attention is paid to the memoir’s pivotal moment: the Countess’s conversion to Catholicism. Following Cserpes (2012), who investigated identity change through network shifts in diaries, we examine how the narrated social world - its central nodes, bridging figures, and relational clusters - changes before and after this event.

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The networks make this shift particularly visible: the Countess's social environment evolves from a predominantly Evangelical group to a more religiously mixed context with a growing Catholic presence. Comparing the top ten brokers (nodes with high betweenness centrality) across phases further supports this - early on, brokerage concentrates among Protestant and familial figures, while Catholic actors become increasingly prominent later. Drawing on Peper/Pözl's six relational categories - kinship, patronage, court, confessional, diplomatic, and household ties - the top brokers in Phase 5 map directly onto the Catholic world she is entering: Eleonore von Strattmann, who introduced her to Viennese court society, hosted her secret conversion, and acted as her personal guarantor, emerges as the pivotal figure (betweenness centrality 0.195), followed by the Jesuit court preacher Franz Xaver Brean, who presided over the conversion, while Strattmann's sister-in-law Eleonore von Batthyány, present at the conversion, also figures among the top brokers. This suggests the conversion was not only a biographical turning point but a measurable reconfiguration of social context.

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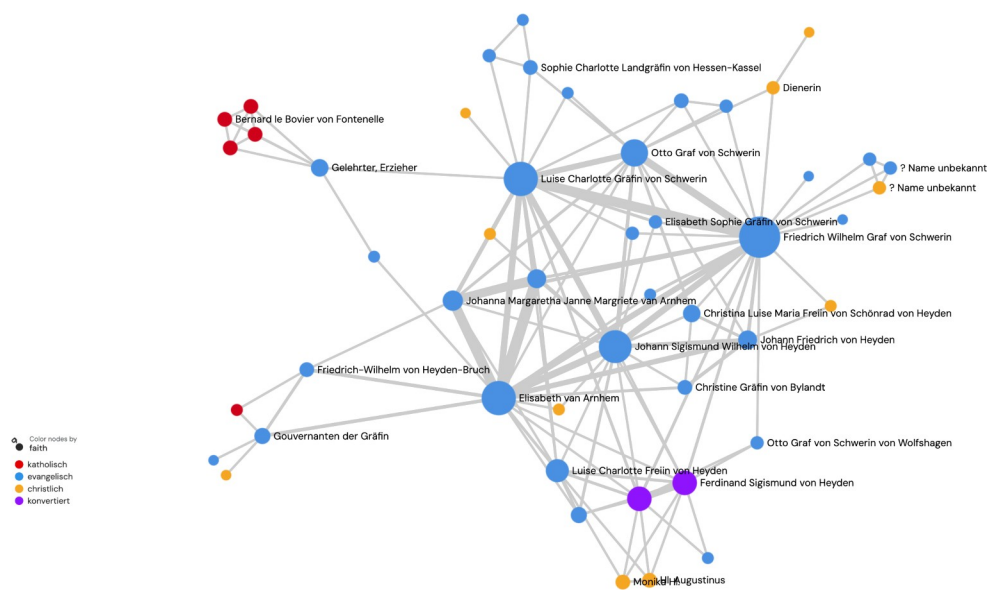


Figure 1. Network of phase 1 (Childhood and Youth until Marriage 1704)

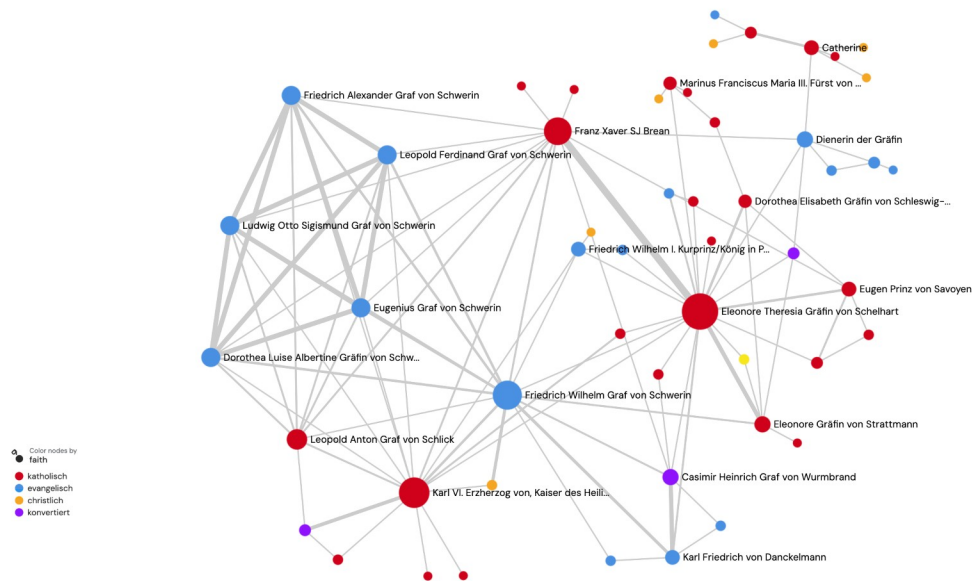


Figure 2. Network of phase 5(Second Stay in Vienna Sept. 1719–Feb. 1720)